

Common Themes and Their Contributions to the Popularity Levels of VOCALOID Music

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1. Introduction

VOCALOID music, or simply Vocaloid, is a commercially available singing synthesizer developed for synthesized singing voices by Yamaha Corporation (Kenmochi and Ohshita, 2007). Users can create synthesized vocals by inputting lyrics and melodies. While it is a synthesizer software, it can also refer to the music made using VOCALOID as a genre.

Vocaloid songs cover a wide range of lyrical subject matter, and highly viewed songs provide an opportunity to examine whether certain lyrical themes recur among popular works. The themes need to be examined in addition to the view counts, as popularity can be measured by quantitative factors, such as view counts, but themes are qualitative and require interpretation.

Given the wide range of lyrical content present in Vocaloid music, this project examines whether particular themes recur among songs that have achieved high levels of popularity. Specifically, the scope of the project was narrowed down to the thirty most viewed Vocaloid songs on YouTube as of July 31, 2026, and asked the following question: Are certain themes disproportionately represented among the most-viewed Vocaloid songs on YouTube? To investigate this, the songs were categorized into their dominant lyrical themes and compared through thematic frequency, cumulative views, and average views per song.

2. Methodology

2.1. Dataset and Song Selection

To identify songs that would be used, the 30 most viewed VOCALOID songs on YouTube were selected, with the view count as the measure of popularity. While there were other options to measure popularity, such as NicoNico Douga, Spotify, and iTunes, YouTube was chosen, as it is a platform that is publicly accessible and provides a consistently observable view count. All recorded data is from July 31, 2026, and treated as a fixed set, as the view counts change daily, given the nature of YouTube. The collected metadata for each song includes: the title, producer, release date, view counts, and the sources of lyrics and translations. Additionally, any form of remixes or other versions of a song were omitted from the count, and only the original versions of the songs were considered.

2.2. Thematic Coding

To identify the themes of each song, the original Japanese lyrics, where applicable, were examined next to the translated version. While interpreting solely from the original Japanese lyrics would have provided a more accurate understanding of the song, an English translation was required given my limited Japanese proficiency, although some recognizable Japanese terms and words served as supporting context. For all thirty songs, Vocaloid Lyrics Wiki (n.d.) was used to reduce variation between different translation sources.

Each song was then assigned a single dominant theme, even when multiple themes were present in the lyrics. The dominant theme was selected based on the idea that was the most recurring and central throughout the song. In cases where it was difficult to single out a theme,

the music video of the respective song was used as supporting, secondary evidence to identify the dominant theme.

After reviewing the songs iteratively, all thirty songs were categorized into one of the eleven finalized thematic categories: conformity, depression, identity, obsession, desire, insecurity, escapism, anxiety, ambition, relationships, and hope. Definitions for each category were established in order to maintain consistent coding throughout all thirty songs. This thematic coding system is inherently interpretive. Some songs on the list could reasonably apply to more than one category, but the same definitions were used consistently, and the theme that best represented the song and its central concern was chosen.

Table 1. Thematic Categories and Definitions

Theme	Definition
Conformity	Changing or performing one's usual behavior or identity to meet social expectations
Depression	Persistent hopelessness, suicidal ideation, emotional despair
Identity	Exploration of self, persona, authenticity, or belonging
Obsession	Unhealthy fixation on another individual or an idea
Desire	Romantic/sexual yearning
Insecurity	Constant doubt or discomfort about self-worth, identity, and relationships
Escapism	The desire to avoid or leave reality
Anxiety	Fears, worries, social unease, uncertainty
Ambition	A drive to act and pursue a goal
Relationships	Emotional/interpersonal connections between people
Hope	Optimism, acceptance, moving forward, etc.

2.3: Data Processing and Visualizations

The collected and coded data were organized based on the general song metadata, respective thematic codes, and the corresponding thematic definitions. Then, the datasets were imported into Power BI, where the song metadata and coding tables were connected using the song titles as the common identifier. Any inconsistencies affecting the relationships between datasets were corrected. Through Power BI, the frequency of a theme within the top thirty songs, total YouTube views by theme, average views by theme, distribution of the top thirty songs by release year, and a table connecting titles with their corresponding themes and metadata were

visualized. An important distinction needs to be made between total views, which displayed how many views are associated with a theme, while the average views helped account for the fact that some themes contain more songs than others.

3. Results

3.1. Theme Frequency

Count of Song by Theme

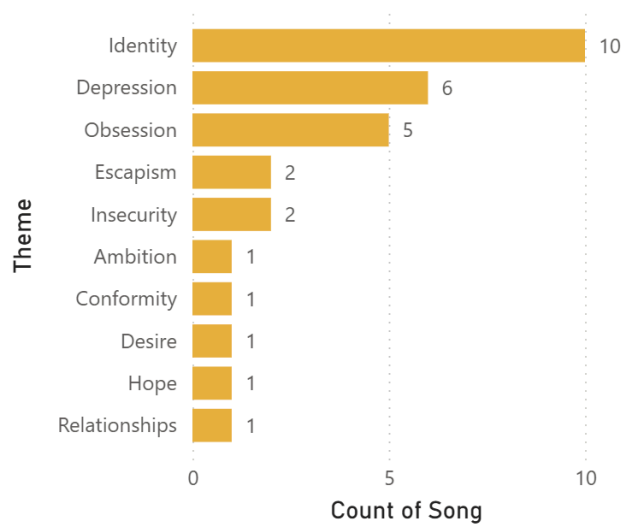


Figure 1. Frequency of thematic categories among the top 30 VOCALOID songs on YouTube

As shown in *Figure 1*, Identity was the theme that appeared most frequently. Out of the thirty songs, ten were identified with the theme of Identity, making up roughly 33.3% of all songs. The second most common theme was Depression, with six songs, followed by Obsession, with five songs. In contrast, themes such as Ambition, Conformity, Desire, Hope, and Relationships each had only one song associated with them. Based on the chart's findings, it appears that the majority of themes only had one to two songs associated with each, and the themes of Identity, Depression, and Obsession were notably more frequent.

3.2. Total Views By Theme

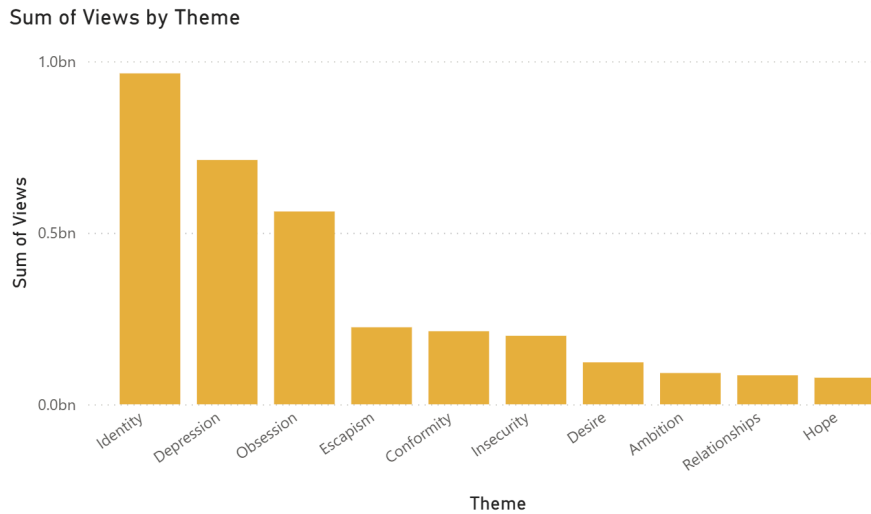


Figure 2. Total sum of YouTube views by theme

Figure 2 presents the total cumulative YouTube views of songs assigned to each theme. As *Figure 1* suggests, the theme of Identity had the highest number of associated songs, and the total view count was also the highest for Identity at approximately 964.9 million total views. Also mirroring the theme frequency, Depression and Obsession had the second and third highest cumulative view counts with approximately 712.2 million and 562 million total views, respectively. The least viewed thematic group was Hope, with approximately 77.5 million total views. The three themes with the highest cumulative views were also the three most frequently occurring themes identified in *Figure 1*, indicating a similar ranking between thematic frequency and cumulative view count.

3.3. Average Views By Theme

Average of Views by Theme

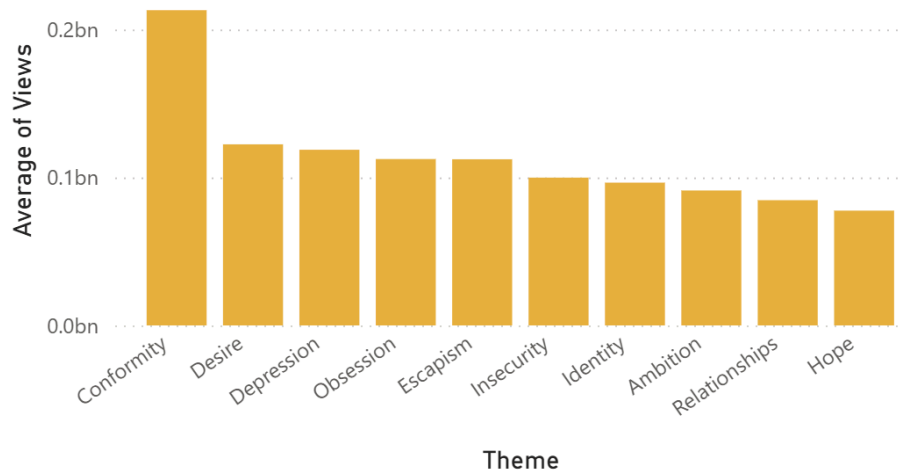


Figure 3. Average views per song within a theme

Unlike *Figure 2*, which provided the total number of views by theme, *Figure 3* presents the average views per song within each theme. Based on the chart, Conformity had the highest average views per song, with approximately 213 million views. Desire and Depression followed Conformity, with average view counts of 122.3 million and 118.7 million, respectively. Hope has the lowest average number of views by theme, with approximately 77.5 million average views per song. Identity, which had the highest number of total cumulative views, sits at the seventh-highest average number of views by theme. However, as presented in *Figure 1*, only one song was associated with the theme of Conformity, meaning that the average view count for the theme is equal to the view count of the single song categorized as Conformity. So, Conformity sitting at number one in average views does not establish that Conformity-themed songs generally perform best.

3.4. Release Year Distribution

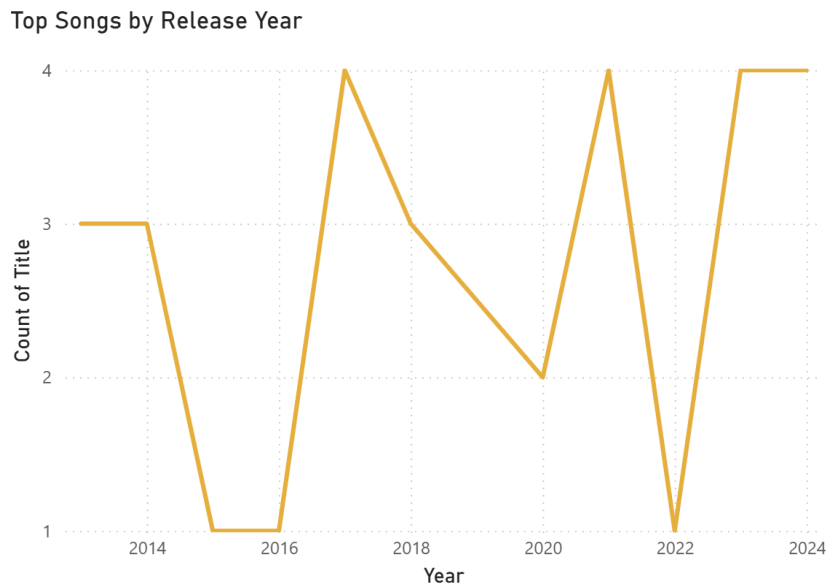


Figure 4. The number of the top 30 songs released in each year

Figure 4 displays the number of the top 30 songs released per year, ranging from 2013 to 2024. 2017, 2021, 2023, and 2024 have the highest number of top 30 releases, with 4 songs per year. As shown on the graph, there is one noticeable low point: 2021 had 4 songs, which dropped to 1 song in 2022. Based on the presented dataset, no single release period overwhelmingly dominates the dataset, despite several local peaks.

4. Discussion

4.1. Recurring Themes Among Popular Songs

Based on the findings of this project, it was shown that Identity was the most frequently occurring theme, with ten out of thirty songs, and it also had the highest cumulative views as a theme. Additionally, Depression and Obsession both followed Identity in frequency and cumulative views. Together, those three themes account for 21 out of 30 songs, or 70 percent of the dataset. This concentration of 70 percent of the dataset within Identity, Depression, and Obsession suggests that the thematic distribution in popular Vocaloid songs is not evenly spread out across the thematic codes. According to *Table 1*, Identity is defined as “Exploration of self, persona, authenticity, or belonging,” Depression is defined as “persistent hopelessness, suicidal ideation, emotional despair,” and Obsession is described as “unhealthy fixation on another individual or an idea.” What can be observed across the three themes is that all of them focus on the inner state of an individual. Specifically, the most represented themes tend to focus on personal interiority. This suggests that inward-facing themes, especially those concerning personal identity, are disproportionately represented within the sample compared with outward-looking or aspirational themes.

4.2. Frequency vs Popularity

According to the data from *Figures 1-3*, it can be seen that Identity was number one in frequency, with a total of ten songs. It was also number one in cumulative views, with approximately 964.9 million views. However, Identity dropped to number seven in average views per song. Meanwhile, Conformity had only one song, yet it ranked number one in average views per song with approximately 213 million views. This result is possible because cumulative

views are influenced by category size. If Identity contains ten songs and Conformity includes one, Identity has ten opportunities to contribute to its cumulative view count. Average view count removes this particular advantage, but it introduces another issue: small sample sizes can produce extreme averages. It can be seen that Conformity's average is not evidence of a recurring pattern because Conformity includes one song with 213 million views, and it averages to 213 million views. This also means that the frequency of a theme among highly viewed songs does not necessarily correspond with higher individual view counts. Therefore, the findings support the existence of recurring thematic patterns in popular Vocaloid songs, but they do not establish that a particular theme causes or predicts popularity.

4.3. Broader Interpretation

The distinction of inward-facing themes may also be considered in relation to Vocaloid's distinctive mode of musical production. The synthesized singer used in Vocaloid music is not an independent songwriter who expresses their own biography. It is the producers who provide the melodies and lyrics performed by the virtual singers. One possible context for the prominence of identity-related themes is Vocaloid's user-centered production model. Yin (2018) notes that users can embed their own self-expression and identity into the Vocaloid productions, while the virtual singers' identities are shaped by the music created by the users. This does not establish that the medium causes identity-focused songs to become popular, but it provides a framework for interpreting why themes of self and internal experience may be compatible with Vocaloid music.

5. Limitations

There were several limitations throughout this project, including limited sample sizes. Only thirty songs were chosen and analyzed, so the results should not be generalized to all of Vocaloid music. In addition, YouTube views were the only metric of a song's popularity, meaning that popularity measured by NicoNico Douga views or Spotify streams could have produced a different sample. Additionally, view counts on YouTube are constantly changing. The dataset used for this project is a snapshot from July 31, 2026. Release year could also play a role in accumulating views. For instance, a song from 2013 would have had substantially more time to gain views than a release from 2024. Furthermore, social media activity and viral content can also influence view counts independently of a song's lyrics or thematic classification.

Regarding the thematic coding, it was interpretive rather than objective, and a song was assigned to a single dominant theme even when the song contained multiple themes. There is also a possibility that another researcher may classify ambiguous songs differently. Another limitation was the potential loss of meaning in translation, as an English translation was used for the interpretation of the lyrics, and using a translation may not fully preserve ambiguity, wordplay, and cultural nuances from the Japanese lyrics. Additionally, music videos were sometimes used as secondary evidence when thematic classification was ambiguous. Because visual interpretation itself is subjective, it adds another layer of interpretation.

With these said limitations, the findings should be understood as an exploratory analysis of thematic patterns within this sample rather than as evidence that certain themes determine the popularity of Vocaloid music as a whole. Future research entailing larger datasets, multiple platforms, and deriving meaning straight from the original Japanese context could provide a more comprehensive analysis.

6. Conclusion

This project examined whether certain themes were disproportionately represented among the most-viewed Vocaloid songs on YouTube. Based on the findings, certain themes were represented substantially more frequently than others. The themes of Identity, Depression, and Obsession collectively accounted for 21 out of 30 songs, representing 70 percent of the dataset.

The most frequently occurring themes were not necessarily associated with the highest average views per song. Identity ranked first in terms of frequency and cumulative views, but only seventh in average views. Instead, the theme of Conformity ranked first in average views despite containing only one song. Therefore, the project identified recurring thematic patterns but found no evidence that any particular theme reliably predicts or causes popularity.

Future research could consider increasing the sample size from 30 to 50 or to the top 100 songs. Also, multiple themes could be accommodated instead of assigning a single dominant theme, and factors such as the producer, the voicebank used, and release years. Rather than identifying a single thematic formula for popularity, the project demonstrates that highly viewed Vocaloid music contains noticeable thematic concentrations while remaining diverse in both subject matter and individual songs' view-count performance.

References

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